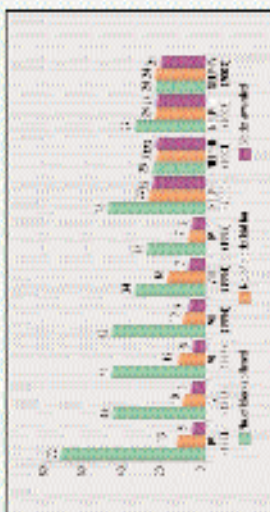


et, Go ...



Quick! Tell us about some childhood memories. Ummm, ok. Kindergarten? Yeah. Being punished in class for talking too much? Hide and seek at the local playground? That was fun. The do-it-yourself colouring book?

Cut to last week. You now have a job, and your friend runs a small business. You meet again, and you realise that the only thing that still binds you to your childhood is colour. Does it really matter that you're a high-flying executive, or that your friend runs a profitable SoHo business?

In school, you had to impress your teacher. At work, you have to impress your boss or the client. So, we come back to our basic premise—no matter where you are, colour is more than just a small component. And what better way to express colour than a well-printed and well-presented document. Colour printers are no longer expensive marvels that sit in a corner, with only the privileged few getting access. For small, yet thriving businesses, printers are indeed engines of growth.

To understand what printers would suit small businesses, we tested five of the best available in the Rs 6,000 to Rs 10,000 range. What about a home user? For him, we

reviewed six colour printers in the range of Rs 2,500 to Rs 5,000. Lexmark's Z605 was the cheapest, while Canon's xnu i255 topped.

On the other hand, we haven't concentrated on the ink cartridges, or consumables. Let's see why. The Lexmark Z605 printer costs around Rs 2,500, while its cartridges cost around Rs 1,800 for both black and colour. Now, if you replace cartridges more than once, you would be actually surpassing the cost at which you brought the printer. It is better to go in for refilled cartridges that are one-fourth the cost or a new one. Or buy a new printer.

These apart, we reviewed three others that could interface with a digital camera to take printouts directly. Although HP and Canon are strong in this particular segment, Canon has the upper hand in compatibility.